

Syllabus

Foundations in Middle School Language Arts

This course prepares sixth grade and beginning middle school students for an advanced middle school language arts curriculum. The course is divided into four units, each of which helps students level-up their reading, writing, and public speaking skills in one of the primary genres of language arts: persuasive speaking, creative writing, research-based expository writing, and literary interpretation. Each unit is designed around a central project that allows students to apply and master these new skills through creative, language-based problem-solving.

The goal of AoPS Academy Language Arts courses is to train the intellectual leaders of the next generation by fostering creative problem solving. In our classes, students tackle projects that are framed as interpretation and communication problems: how can we communicate an idea in just the right way? Or, how can we understand complex ideas that are being communicated to us? To solve these problems, students must craft written pieces and oral presentations that demonstrate mastery of the Language Arts skills they learned in class. In this way, our courses help students develop the confidence and advanced literacy skills they need to solve any communication problem they encounter, whether it's in college, in the professional world, or in their own lives.

Time Commitment: This 36-week course includes 105 minutes of in-class instruction and 60-90 minutes of homework each week, corresponding to a full-year course.

Homework: Students should expect to spend about 1-2 hours on homework every week. Homework will include: practicing skills learned in class through questions in the course homepage, long-term writing assignments connected to the unit project, and assigned reading in one of the four quarterly textbooks.

Content:

Week	Topic
1	Anatomy of a Speech
2	Elements of a Speech: Pathos
3	Elements of a Speech: Ethos
4	Elements of a Speech: Logos
5	Draft Your Teachin' Speech
6	Inject Personality with Asides
7	Sentence Variety
8	Revision
9	Speech Performances
10	Descriptive Writing
11	Pronouns and Point of View
12	Verb Tense and Backstory
13	Diction and Characterization
14	Punctuation and Dialogue
15	Paragraphs and Pacing
16	Strong Verbs and Storytelling
17	First Line Workshops
18	Author Reading

Week	Topic
19	Features and Concept Maps
20	Qualities of Development
21	Digging Deeper
22	Story Maps
23	Query Letter and Theme
24	Structure
25	Organization
26	Titles and Revision
27	The Editorial Board
28	Introduction to Shakespeare
29	Recognizing Humor in Shakespeare
30	Tackling Long Speeches in Shakespeare
31	Understanding Character in Shakespeare
32	Performing in a Scene
33	Learning Your Lines
34	Performing Humor
35	Revision and Rehearsal
36	Midsummer Showdown

The course is divided into four project-based units:

Unit	Description	Common Core Standards	Core Skills or Concepts
1 Fundamentals of Persuasion	Students produce a written work and public presentation that represents their mastery of causal reasoning and the fundamentals of persuasion. Book: <i>Philosophy for Kids</i>	RL 6.1 RI 6.4, 6.5, 6.6, 6.7 W 6.2A, 6.2B, 6.2D, 6.4, 6.5, 6.9 SL 6.1A, 6.1B, 6.4, 6.6 L 6.3A, 6.3B, 6.4B	Close reading; discriminating between fact and opinion; reflective writing; aspects of rhetorical arguments (ethos, pathos, logos); rhetorical fallacies; cause and effect in constructing an argument; public speaking; revision and feedback
2 Grammar and Creative Writing	Students read short stories and explore how writers wield grammatical tools to refine their writing, and they create a portfolio of creative pieces, one of which is revised for an author reading. Book: <i>Flying Lessons and Other Stories</i>	RL 6.1, 6.2, 6.3, 6.5, 6.6, 6.9 W 6.3A, 6.3B, 6.3C, 6.3D, 6.3E, 6.4, 6.5 SL 6.4, 6.6 L 6.1A, 6.1B, 6.2B, 6.3A, 6.3B	Techniques for descriptive writing; implementing narrative point of view; action, and pacing; diction; formatting effective dialogue; revision; strong and weak verbs; giving and receiving feedback
3 Research and Expository Writing	Students develop strong research skills as they research, draft, and revise an engaging feature article, all following the process students would undertake if they chose to submit their work for publication in a real magazine. Book: <i>Muse</i> , "Mysteries of the Deep"	RL 6.2 RI 6.1, 6.3, 6.5 W 6.1.B, 6.2.A-B, F, 6.3.A-B, 6.4, 6.5, 6.6, 6.7, 6.8, 6.9, 6.10 SL 6.1, 6.4	Feature articles; concept mapping; evaluating the reliability of online sources; bias; theme; annotated bibliography; plagiarism; quoting; organizing and structuring a feature article.
4 Shakespeare and Literary Analysis	Students learn all the skills necessary to understand, analyze, and enjoy A Midsummer Night's Dream by William Shakespeare. This culminates in a competition where students analyze and perform selections from the play. Book: <i>Midsummer Night's Dream</i>	RL 6.1, 6.2, 6.3, 6.4 SL 6.1, 6.4 W 6.1.A-B, 6.2.B, 6.4, 6.5, 6.6, 6.9, 6.10 L 6.1E, 6.4A	Strategies for comprehending Shakespeare; literary analysis; Elizabethan English; close reading; humor; message, indirect characterization; audience; verse and prose; peer review; revision; performance.

To interpret the Common Core Standards column on the table above, visit the Common Core ELA website at www.corestandards.org/ELA-Literacy.